Panikkar's life to give the reader a ringside view of the unfolding saga of the two world wars, of revolution and of fascism, of national movements and social fractures, of power play and nation-building.

Panikkar was a true polymath. He was equally at home penning verses in Malayalam and Sanskrit as he was exploring India's ancient connections with Asia and beyond. He was always looking for broad conceptualisations to explain complexity. He was not communal but saw Hinduism as providing the cultural fabric that kept India whole through the ages. He was convinced that an independent India needed a strong centre to survive and flourish. He accepted Partition as necessary to enable a strong centre in both the succeeding states of India and Pakistan. Accommodating Muslim aspirations would only have been possible in a weak, undivided state. As he wrote to his friend Syed Mahmud, "I have for a long time now been a Pakistanist. Without the separation of Pakistan, a central government will not be possible in India. The fear of Hindu majority at the centre, whatever safeguards you may create and whatever pacts you may work out, will drive the Muslims to unreasonable madness."

Panikkar manifested in his own prodigious writings the contradictions of his age, attempting, through his study of history, to comprehend the deeper currents shaping the 20th century. Some of his books still remain the authoritative sources for the study of Indian history, the best known being his volumes on the Indian Ocean. *The Strategic Problems of the Indian Ocean* was published in 1944 followed by the more substantive *India and the Indian Ocean: An Essay on the Influence of Sea Power on Indian History* in 1945. He was one of the first scholars to identify the absence of sea power as the reason why India fell prey to western imperialism. For independent India, he said, having a strong navy was indispensable to maintaining its sovereignty and territorial integrity.

**PANIKKAR SERVED IN PRINCELY KINGDOMS AS WELL AS INDEPEDENT INDIA, EMBODYING THE ERA'S POLITICAL CHURN**

In the final phase of his eventful career, Panikkar excelled as a diplomat, serving as India's ambassador to China and later to Egypt. He established close relations with China's revolutionary leaders, Mao Zedong and Zhou Enlai, but was criticised for ignoring the warning signs already visible about the clashing nationalisms of the two emerging Asian powers. His stint as ambassador to Cairo brought all his skills as a diplomat to the fore, presaging the subsequent birth of the Non-Aligned Movement.

Panikkar died in 1963, while serving as Vice-Chancellor of Mysore University. He was mourned not only throughout India but across the world. He was witness to history but also an active participant in it. Basu's biography is a fine tribute to one of the giants of our age. ■

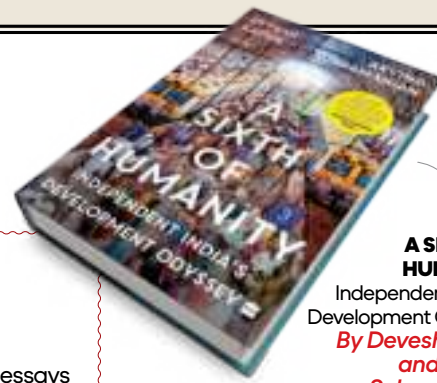
***—Shyam Saran***




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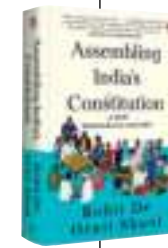
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***—Compiled by Amit Dixit***